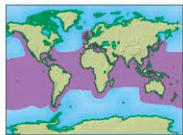


Pseudorca crassidens

False killer whale



Location Temperate and tropical waters worldwide

Length 20 ft
(Up to 6.1 m)

Weight 2½ tons
(Up to 2.2 tonnes)

Social unit Group

Status Data deficient



One of the largest dolphins, this rapid swimmer has a long, slim body and a tall, sicklelike dorsal fin. Coloration is uniform black or slate-gray,

with a paler underside patch between the flippers, and perhaps pale patches on the sides of the head. It prefers deep oceans but appears occasionally off oceanic islands, in schools of 10–20, rarely up to 300. Equipped with 7–11 pairs of large, conical teeth in both the upper and lower jaws, this formidable hunter pursues large oceanic fish, such as salmon, tuna, and barracuda. It also takes squid and even smaller dolphins.

CONSERVATION

The false killer whale makes a wide variety of echolocating and communicating sounds, such as clicks and whistles. It also leaps with agility and skillfully surfs breakers and ship bow waves. However, this confident navigator is often stranded on beaches in vast groups of up to 1,000. Why this happens is not known but, with help to return to the water, some survive.



BULL-NOSED WHALE

The pronounced, rounded melon combined with the absence of a beak gives the false killer whale a bull-nosed profile.

Globicephala macrorhynchus

Short-finned pilot whale



Location Temperate and tropical waters worldwide

Length 16–23 ft
(5–7 m)

Weight 1½–3½ tons
(1.5–3.5 tonnes)

Social unit Group

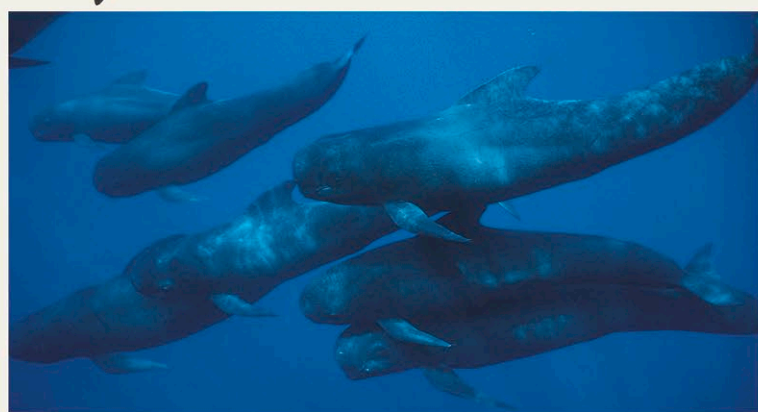
Status Data deficient



Nocturnally active, the pilot whale feeds mainly on deep-water squid and octopus, diving below 1,600 ft (500 m) for more than 15 minutes. There are 2 very similar species: the short-finned (*Globicephala macrorhynchus*) has smaller flippers (pectoral fins) than the long-finned pilot whale (*Globicephala melas*). In both, there is an anchor-shaped pale patch on the throat and chest, and white streaks behind the dorsal fin and each eye. Females are about half the weight of males, but live 15 years longer, up to 60 years. Along with skin scarring, these features suggest competition between males with

BONDING

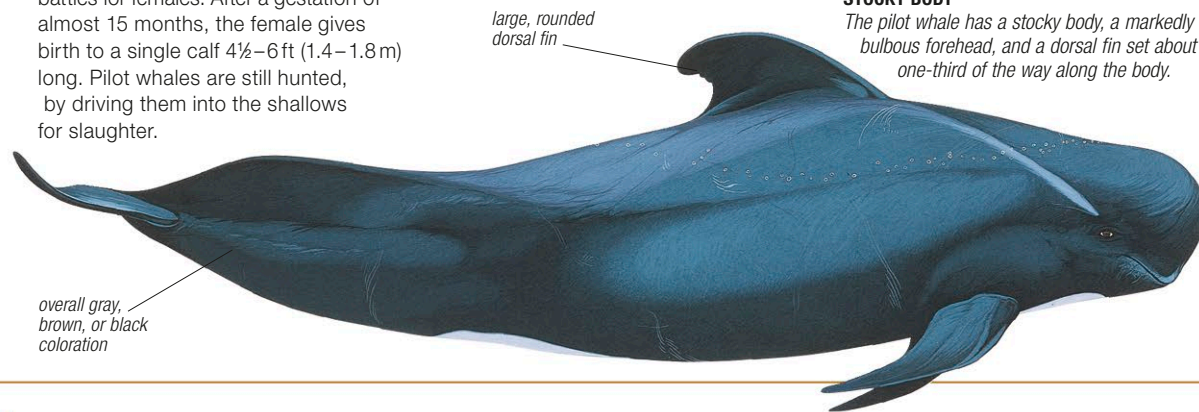
Pilot whales form schools of tens to hundreds and also associate with other cetaceans such as bottlenose and common dolphins, and minke whales. Within a pilot whale school, adults form long-term bonds and probably recognize each other by individual “signature” whistles. However, many offspring are not closely related genetically to the school’s males, suggesting that mating occurs between schools. Females past reproductive age may suckle calves that are not their own.



battles for females. After a gestation of almost 15 months, the female gives birth to a single calf 4½–6 ft (1.4–1.8 m) long. Pilot whales are still hunted, by driving them into the shallows for slaughter.

STOCKY BODY

The pilot whale has a stocky body, a markedly bulbous forehead, and a dorsal fin set about one-third of the way along the body.

*Hyperoodon ampullatus*

Northern bottlenose whale



Location North Atlantic

Length 20–33 ft
(6–10 m)

Weight 7¼–9¾ tons
7.5–10 tonnes

Social unit Individual/
Group

Status Data deficient



The northern bottlenose whale is one of about 22 species of beaked whales—mostly medium-sized, open-ocean cetaceans that make long, deep dives for squid, starfish, fish, crab, and other food. This species has a bulging forehead and dolphinlike beak. Males, which grow larger than females, have 2 tusklike teeth growing

at the tip of the beak. Other teeth are present but the degree of growth above the surface of the gums (eruption) is very variable. Feeding is probably by suction, using the tongue as a piston to draw in water, seabed mud, and prey. The body of the northern bottlenose

whale is long and slim, the flippers small, and the erect dorsal fin is set about two-thirds of the way to the tail. Like most other beaked whales, this species congregates in small groups with 1–4 members, but can be up to 20 individuals, usually all of the same sex and of similar ages.

